



DRESDEN DESTROYED

Survivors search through the ruins of the city of Dresden, destroyed by Allied bombers in February 1945. An estimated 60,000 people died in the raids on Dresden, which became a focus for critics of the morality of strategic bombing.

Allied fighters. In the final months of the war, out of favor with the Nazi hierarchy, Galland reverted to a role as squadron commander, and, grouping some of the few surviving Luftwaffe aces around him, formed Jagdverband 44 (JV44) to fly jets in a final self-consciously futile gesture of defiance. Nothing, however, could disguise the fact that German cities were by then wide open to bombing by day or night. The destruction of Dresden in February 1945 and the reduction of Berlin to gaunt smoldering ruins constituted a belated fulfillment of the apocalyptic vision of the advocates of strategic bombing.

New bomber

Japan was spared from bombing until late in the war because of sheer distance. After the one-time carrier-borne Doolittle raid of April 1942 (see page 225), targets in Japan were not struck again until the summer of 1944, when America's new B-29 bombers came into operation. The B-29 Superfortress marked an impressive advance in military aviation. It had a range of approximately 4,000 miles (6,400km) – double that of a B-17 – and a top speed of 350mph (560kph). The crew worked in conditions that made earlier bombers seem primitive, with heated pressurized cabins to avoid the unpleasant effects of high-altitude flight and remote-controlled guns operated by gunners using computerized sights. The downside was that

the USAAF rushed the new bomber into service with inadequate testing. From June 1944 B-29s based in India, operating via Nationalist-controlled southwest China, were sent to attack Japan. Mounting these raids from Asia posed formidable logistical problems, and also led to substantial losses through various kinds of equipment failure and engine fires, as well as enemy action.

Far East offensive

In late November 1944, the B-29s began a sustained offensive from bases on the Marianas Islands in the Pacific. For three months they pounded Japan from high altitude in daylight, using the same “precision-bombing” tactics as had been employed over Germany. This was of limited effect. Flying at 30,000ft (9,000m) in the Siberian jetstream, encountering winds of 200mph (320kph), navigators frequently failed to find their targets and, with cloud cover most days, bombardiers could not hit them if they did.

In March 1945 General Curtis LeMay instigated new tactics. The B-29s were sent in by night at low altitude. Stripped of their armament to save weight, they carried a maximum load of mostly incendiary bombs. On the night of March 9, 1945 B-29s started a firestorm that destroyed almost a quarter of Tokyo and may have killed 80,000 people. Bombers arrived back at their island bases blackened with soot. Night after night, other cities suffered a similar fate. Soon most Japanese people had fled to the countryside, industrial production had plummeted, and transportation links were cut. Even before the dropping of the atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki in August 1945, strategic bombing had crippled Japan's ability to continue the war.

airfields coming under attack and their fuel reserves shrinking, by 1945 the Luftwaffe was more or less a spent force.

German jet fighter

German fighter ace and air-defense chief Adolf Galland always held that the outcome could have been different if Germany had correctly played its trump card: the Messerschmitt Me 262 jet fighter. When he first flew an Me 262 in May 1943, he described the experience as like being “pushed by angels.” Around 100mph (160kph) faster than any propeller-driven fighter, the jet was the defensive weapon Galland had been looking for, capable of penetrating any fighter cover that the bombers might receive.

The Me 262 project had been subject to frustrating delays – the airframe had been ready in 1941, but it had taken a long time to settle on a suitable engine and tackle problems with take-off and landing. Now, Galland hoped that it would be mass-produced and deployed as an impenetrable shield around Germany. Hitler did not agree. Obsessed with his search for an offensive “secret weapon” to win the war, the Führer insisted that the Me 262 be developed as a bomber. Against his wishes, a small number of the jet fighters were produced and an experimental combat unit was set up in Lechfeld in southern Germany to try them out. The Me 262 had many problems. It was difficult to fly and downright dangerous to land – the landing speed was high, requiring a long runway and putting excessive strain on the tires, which were liable to burst. Engine “flameouts” were disturbingly common. And although the outpaced Allied fighter pilots could not pursue the Me 262s, they found that they could pick them off by waiting over their airfields and pouncing as the jets returned to land.

Yet despite its faults, the Me 262 did take its toll of Allied bombers. In the last months of the war the jets proved they could survive in the air when Bf 109s and Fw 190s were being shot down in their hundreds by the numerically superior

WALTER NOWOTNY

THE MAN CHOSEN TO LEAD the Luftwaffe's first fully operational jet-fighter squadron was an Austrian, Major Walter Nowotny (1920–44). Aged 23, Nowotny was a renowned fighter ace, a veteran of the Russian front with 225 credited victories, proud wearer of the Knight's Cross with Oak Leaves, Swords, and Diamonds. In October 1944 the Me 262s of Kommando Nowotny were based at Achmer and Heseper airfields near the border with the Netherlands, on the main flight path for US bombers attacking Germany. For a month Nowotny led his pilots into battle in their often-faulty, accident-prone jets, before meeting an almost inevitable fate. On November 8, during a visit to the Achmer airfield by fighter chief Adolf Galland, Nowotny took off for the last time to engage the bombers and their fighter escorts. He shot down a Consolidated B-24 and possibly a

LUFTWAFFE ACE

Major Walter Nowotny was credited with 258 victories in aerial combat, mostly on the Eastern Front, before his death flying a Messerschmitt Me 262.

Mustang before one of his engines burst into flames. His jet dived into the ground alongside the airfield. RAF pilot Pierre Clostermann recalled that when news of Nowotny's death came through, he was remembered “almost with affection” as a brave enemy, belonging to the fraternity of fighter pilots who knew “no ideologies, no hatred, and no frontiers.”

